



WARRING MONKS Galta Peeth mahant Avdheshacharya; below, Jagatguru Rambhadracharya at a Ram Katha in Jaipur, Nov. 14

RAJASTHAN

Running Tussle Over Galta

A MUCH DISPUTED PEETH

- **Both Ramanuja and Ramanandi sects claim Galta Peeth; control of temple property, appointment of a hereditary mahant are sticking points**
- **Ramanandis say Avdheshacharya's appointment as mahant in 2006 by linear succession is invalid**
- **In July 2024, the HC agreed, ordered state to take over; BJP, too, favours Ramanandis**

The other prominent Vaishnavite sect, the Ramanandis, have also laid claim to Galta. Their main argument has been that a *mahant* cannot marry. The Ramanuja tradition allows its *mathadheesh* (head of the monastery) to marry, while the Ramanandi sect demands celibacy from its *mahants*. It is, however, well recorded that several past generations of Galta *mahants* had been married and picked by succession.

In July 2024, in a decisive move, the Rajasthan High Court ordered the state government to take over the administration of Galta Peeth, replacing Avdheshacharya. Calling the latter's appointment "illegal", the ruling said that after the death of Ramodaracharya in 2006, only the state government had the right to appoint a *mahant*, and asked it to "restore its status to that of 1943". However, it must be remembered that the *peeth* was never under the direct control of the erstwhile Jaipur state or, later, Rajasthan. Once a *mahant* was chosen, the state was duly notified. The 1943 appointment of Ramodaracharya was an exception because the sitting *mahant* died without a male heir.

Following the HC order, the Devasthan department of the state government, which looks after matters related to religious institutions, appointed the Jaipur district collector as administrator of the Galta Ji Temple Trust. The DC has formed a committee to oversee the temple management.

The BJP government is perceived to be supporting the Ramanandis; many link it to the sect's long association with the Ram Janmabhoomi temple movement. At a Ram Katha event on November 14, in the presence of Rajasthan chief minister Bhajan Lal Sharma, Jagatguru Rambhadracharya, a prominent Ramanandi monk, recently demanded that the *peeth* be handed over to a public trust headed by a Ramanandi functionary. He also claimed he influenced Sharma's elevation to power. The demand reflects the political significance of this sectarian battle. Adding to the controversy, a video showed BJP Rajya Sabha MP Ghanshyam Tiwari praising CM Sharma for the government's takeover of the *peeth*. Asserting that Galta belonged to the Ramanandis, he accused Ramodaracharya of affiliating it with the Ramanuja sect to justify his marriage. The charge is an old one, and Avdheshacharya has countered it by emphasising that the *peeth* is a *math* with a wider field of activity, not merely a temple, and that its leadership has followed Ramanuja customs for generations.

The July 2024 Rajasthan HC decision has reignited the Ramanuja-Ramanandi dispute. While past BJP governments have already been set against Avdheshacharya, the current administration's actions align with a broader push to elevate the Ramanandi influence. The future of Galta Peeth remains uncertain, caught at the intersection of religious tradition, politics and judicial intervention. ■